Labor Perception Cheat Sheet

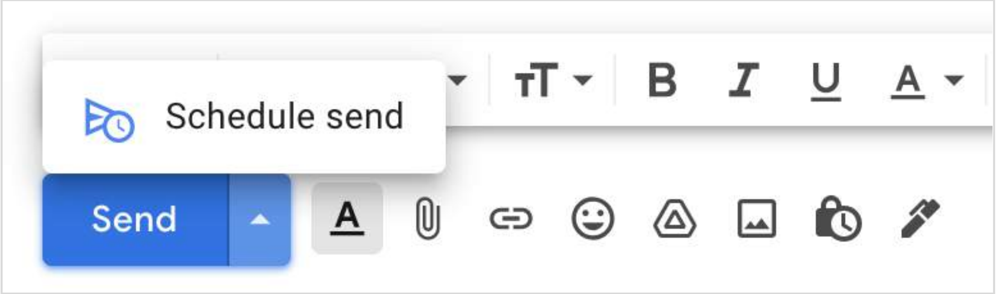
BONUS CONTENT

👁️ 11 additional examples of the Labor Perception bias

Here are more *Labor Perception* examples from different companies and industries:

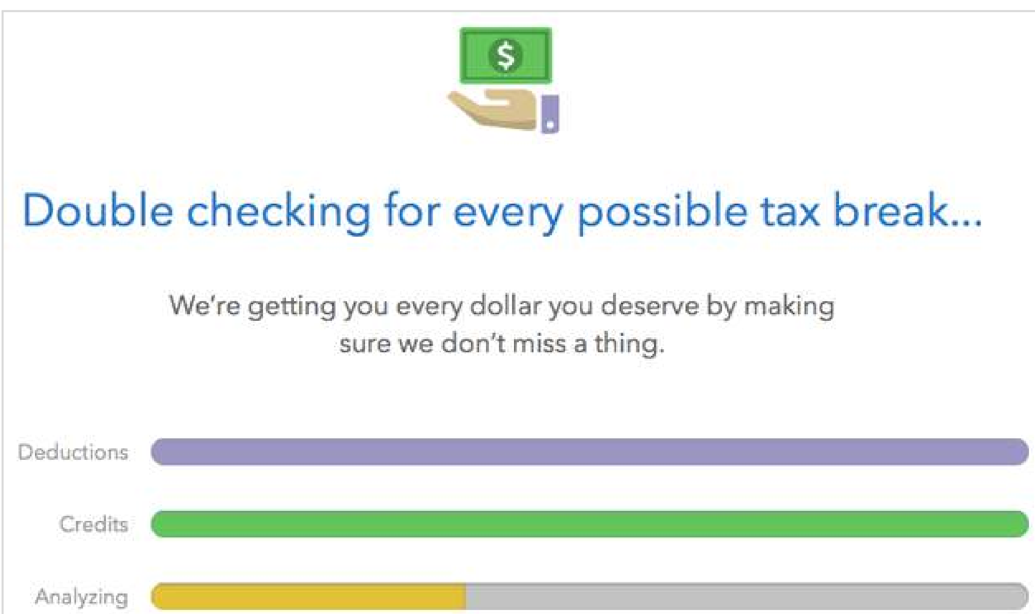
1. **Domino's Pizza**
   Domino's pizza online order experience shows a preview of the next steps right after you order. It includes steps like "Order placed, Prep, Bake, Quality Check, Delivery". Interestingly, it's just an approximation based on the average order time, but the reassurance of the "*Quality Check*" step increases the perceived value of the pizza you're about to receive.

2. **Gmail Schedule Send**
   Have you ever used "Schedule Sent" in your email inbox? There are typically two situations when people use that feature:
   a) to land in someone's inbox at a better time (e.g., avoid the week-end), or
   b) to avoid replying so quickly that the recipient might think it's an automated reply. It's another way of showing that it "took you some time" to craft your answer.

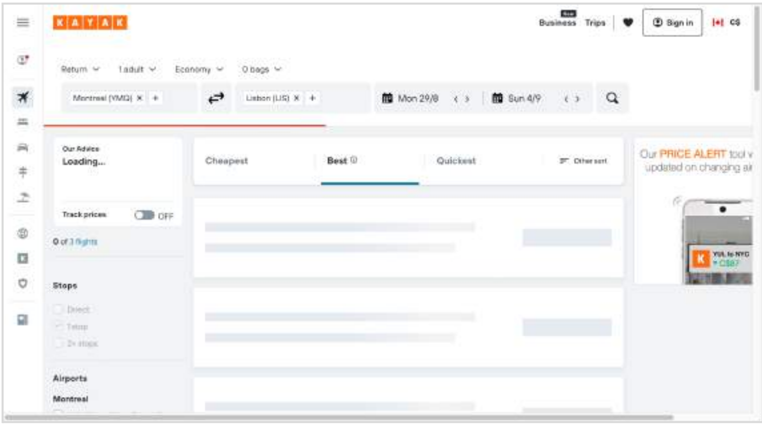


3. **Visible restaurant kitchens**
   Diners rated the quality of food from those restaurants as 22% higher than the same food when they could not see it being prepared.[ref] This shows that the *Labor Perception* bias isn't just about time but also about *operational transparency*.

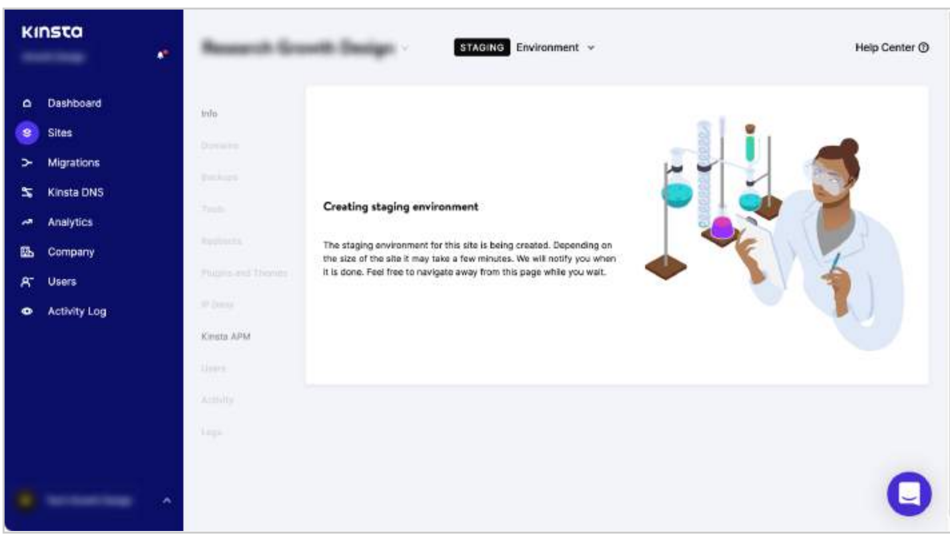
4. **TurboTax:**
   "The process of completing a tax return often has at least some level of stress and anxiety associated with it," said Rob Castro, a spokesperson for TurboTax's parent company, Intuit. "To offset these feelings, we use a variety of design elements—content, animation, movement, etc.—to ensure our customers' peace of mind that their returns are accurate and they are getting all the money they deserve."[ref]



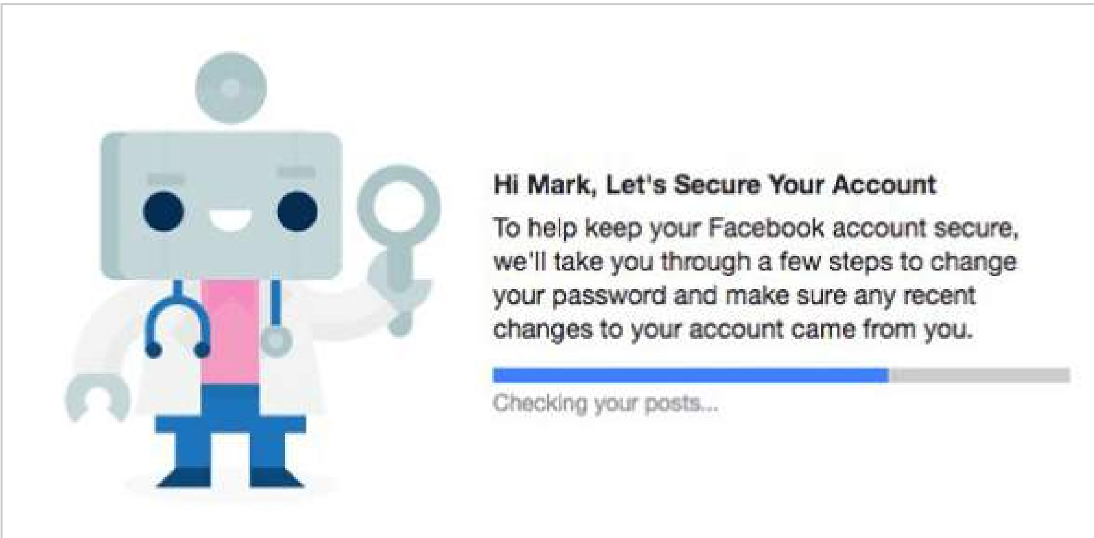
5. **Kayak**
   Back when online travel booking was a new concept, this travel booking site used to delay the time search results page to show that it was "crunching a lot of data."



6. **Kinsta**
   Kinsta is a Wordpress hosting company with a great admin dashboard. When you create a staging environment or a backup, they show a clever animation of a scientist working hard to build your experimental staging environment.

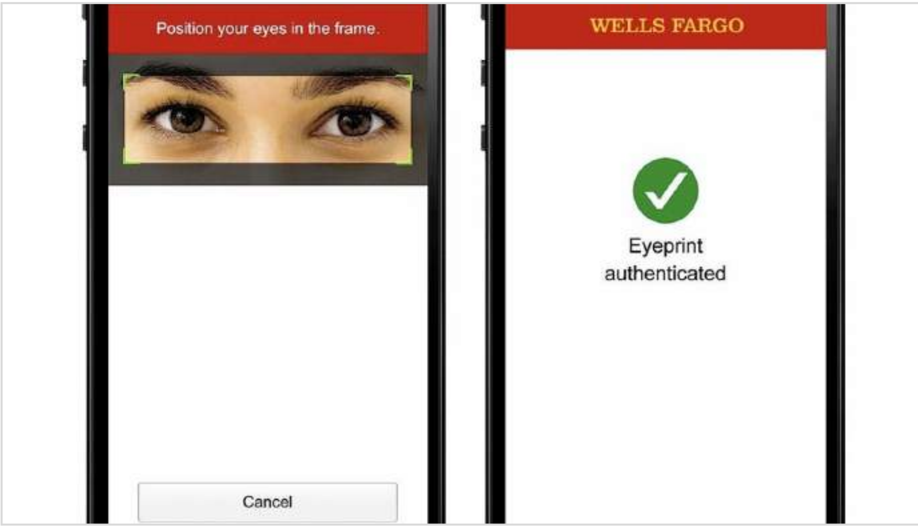


7. **Facebook's security checkup**
   A Facebook spokesperson wrote: *"While our systems perform these checks at a much faster speed than people can actually see, it's important that they understand what we do behind the scenes to protect their Facebook account. UX can be a powerful education tool and walking people through this process at a slower speed allows us to provide a better explanation and an opportunity for people to review and understand each step along the way."*[ref]

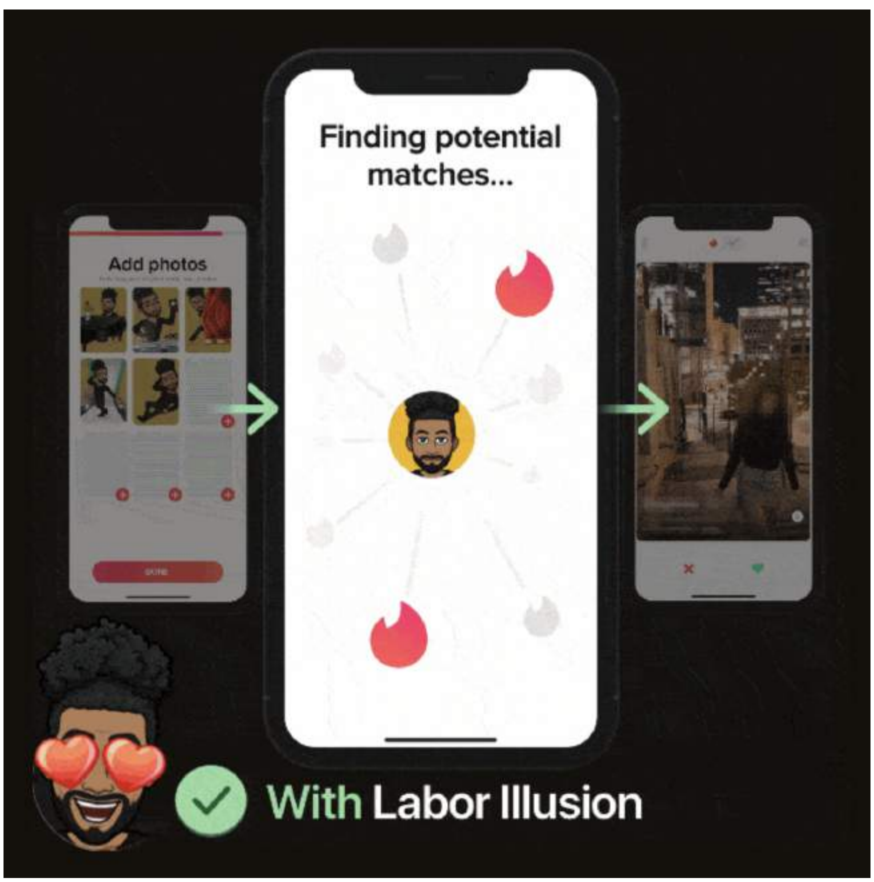


8. **Live Dashboard (New York Times)**
   In 2016, the NYT's "Trump vs. Clinton" live forecast needles were in constant motion—back and forth, back and forth—adding to the anxiety of the moment. It was later found that the needles were jiggling randomly (though within the margin of error)[ref].

9. **Wells Fargo Bank**
   Wells Fargo admitted to slowing down its app's retinal scanners, because customers didn't realize they worked otherwise.[ref]

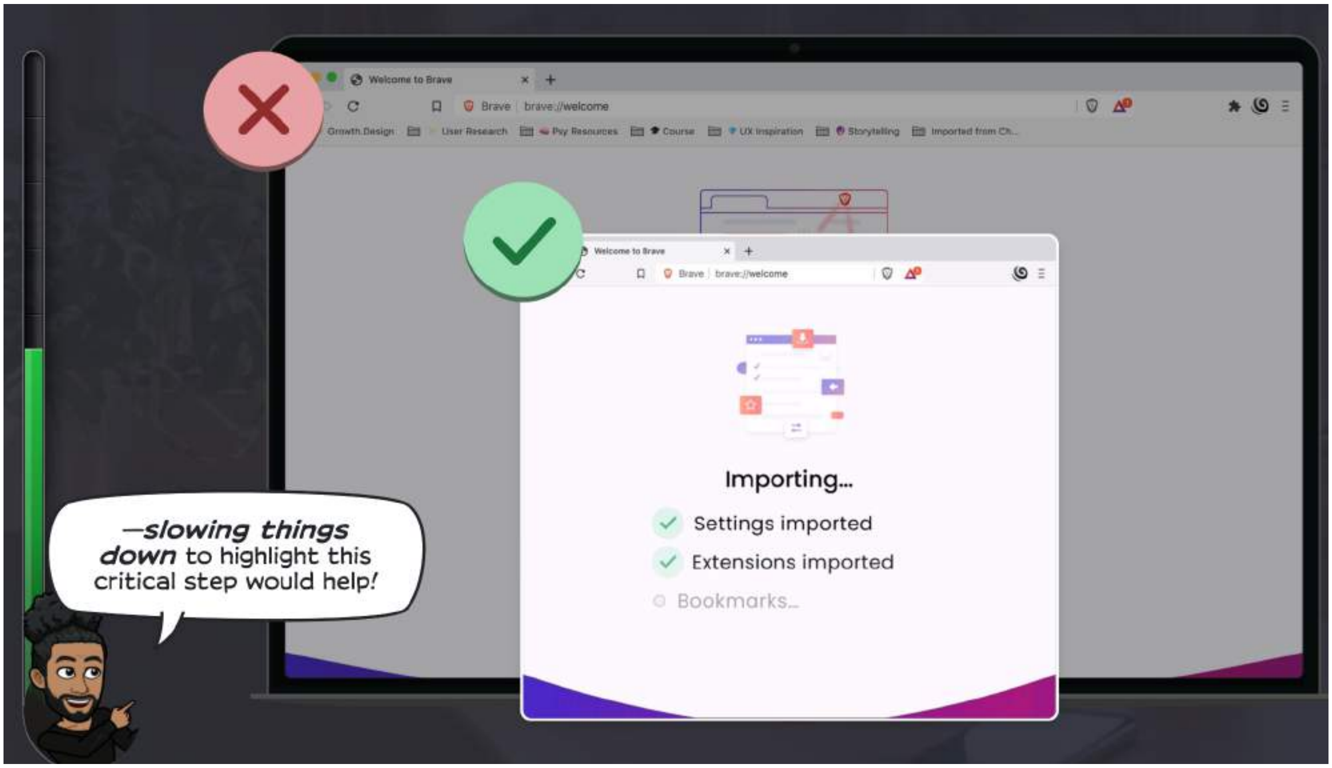


10. **Tinder**
    The first time you see your potential Tinder matches after you complete your profile, Tinder shows the results so quickly that you might doubt the quality of the results (see full case study here). Adding a quick loading step might help:



11. Brave

Brave is a new privacy-first browser. During [their onboarding](), the import of your bookmarks from your existing browser is so quick that it's easy to miss and think it didn't work. Brave could slow things down to offer a better user experience ([full case study here]()):



Your turn.

What's another example of *Labor Perception bias* that you've seen in the wild? Share it with us at [team@growth.design]()

—Dan Benoni & Louis-Xavier Lavallée

DO's and DON'Ts

DON'T use the *Labor Perception* bias if it's:

- ☐ **Too slow**: Waiting periods beyond 30 seconds tend to hurt the perceived value.[1]
- ☐ **Irrelevant**: The waiting animations & text must focus clearly on user benefits.
- ☐ **Detrimental**: The Labor Illusion doesn't make the user feel genuinely better.
- ☐ **Unethical:** See *Two Ethical Rules* checklist below.

DO use *Labor Perception* bias if...

- ☐ **Waiting is unavoidable.** In other words, if you can't avoid making your users wait (e.g., a long search query, a database import, etc.), you might as well use the operational transparency (showing and educating the user regarding the work behind the waiting period).
- ☐ **User expectations are high**: The user has high expectations for the step following their action (e.g., submitting your taxes after 15 hrs of work). To validate those expectations, you need to do the user research to identify the user's state at that exact step:
    - ☐ How do they feel? (e.g., anticipation, hope, and other elements from the [Behavior Map](#))
    - ☐ What's the perceived value? (e.g., money or time invested)
    - ☐ What's at risk for them? (e.g., submitting payment, social security number)

⚖️ Two Ethical Golden Rules

You may have noticed that we use "Labor ***Perception***" instead of the official terminology "Labor ***Illusion***." That's because we strongly believe in the ethical limits behind these kinds of effects.

Calling this bias a Labor "Illusion" assumes that the waiting should always be faked, which is not true (a real, well-crafted labor demonstration can reap the same benefits as an illusory one). That terminology insinuates deception, whereas we focus on improving the customer experience.

We agree with Dr. E. Adar[ref] when it comes to applying the labor perception bias ethically:

- [ ] Favor non-deceptive solutions to problems whenever possible
- [ ] If that's not possible, the "benevolent labor illusion" should:
    - [ ] Reassure, not manipulate
    - [ ] Improve the product measurably
    - [ ] Most user should prefer the "illusion" solution when asked

📈 Business Impact

- A well-designed effect can increase your app's perceived value by **up to 15%**[ref].

- The net lift on activation, retention & revenues depends a lot on your context (waiting duration, audience, product, etc). But still, it's definitely worth testing.

🌱 Your next steps

- ☑ ~~**1. Understand**: Read and understand the Labor Perception case study.~~
- ☐ **2. Identify:** Find a critical moment where your product could show the hard work expected to deliver value to your users. Make sure you respect the previous rules and checklists.
- ☐ **3. Empathize**: Using customer research, write down the user state at that moment (key emotions, expectations, feelings, perceived value and benefits, risks).
- ☐ **4. Ideate**: Brainstorm 3 experiments to make the anticipation more delightful and reassuring.
- ☐ **5. Experiment:** Experiment between the 'delay' & 'no delay' variants (user testing or A/B split)

🔗 References and Links

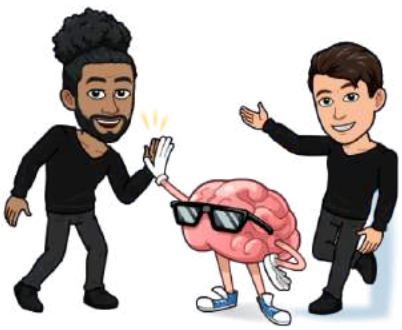
- Labor Illusion: How Operational Transparency Increases Perceived Value, Harvard (2011)
- Reciprocal Value And Operational Transparency, *Harvard (2015)*
- The UX Secret That Will Ruin Apps For You, *Mark Wilson (2016)*
- Banks Opt to Scan Fingers and Faces Instead, *New York Times (2016)*
- Why progress bars can make you feel better, *BBC (2019)*
- Why some apps use fake progress bars, *The Atlantic (2017)*
- Benevolent Deception, *Eytan Adar* (2013)

💡 Want to use psychology to build better products?

If you're looking for more ways to sharpen your product skills using psychology, check these out:

Product Psychology Course.

If you want to learn how to use psychology to create better experiences for your customers, check out our course: https://growth.design/course



Cognitive Biases Cheatsheet.

100+ cognitive biases and design principles that affect your product experiences. Tons of product examples, tips, and checklists to improve your user experience: https://growth.design/psychology

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